

FAITH FULL Andhra CM Chandrababu Naidu visits Tirumala in June after his victory

Photographs: ANI

and is gearing up to go national.

Meanwhile, in UP, the Yogi Adityanath government stirred up a controversy in July when it directed shopkeepers selling food along the route of the Kanwar Yatra to display their names (and thereby their religion) outside their establishments. It earned a rebuke and a stay from the Supreme Court. But that hasn't stopped the Yogi regime from reviving a state-level drive on a similar directive issued in September (see *Proof of Credentials*).

The politics of purity has struck Congress-ruled states as well. In the last week of September, Himachal Pradesh minister Vikramaditya Singh stunned his Congress colleagues by posting a "UP-like" announcement on social media, making it mandatory for vendors and restaurant owners to display their names on their establishment. Vikramaditya was pulled up by the state leadership and even had to come to New Delhi to explain the situation to the party leadership.

THE POLITICS OF PRASAD

As for the Tirupati laddoo, while neither the RSS nor its affiliates such as the Bajrang Dal and the VHP have blown up the issue too much presently, it's likely a tactical wait: they are pushing the Naidu government to hand over the probe to the Central Bureau of Investigation and took out protests in various districts across the country. Meanwhile, refuting the accusations against him, Jagan declared he would visit Tirumala on September 28 "to atone for the sins of Naidu" in an attempt to regain some political mileage. But after an emotionally charged right-wing campaign on social media demanded that the former CM sign a declaration about his "faith in Lord Venkateswara" if he wanted darshan, Jagan, who is a Christian, cancelled the trip. (Since 1990, such a 'declaration of faith' has been mandatory for non-Hindus visiting the shrine.)

THE SC CHASTISED CM NAIDU FOR MAKING STATEMENTS ON PURITY WITHOUT PROOF, SAYING KEEP THE "GODS AWAY FROM POLITICS"

Even during its poll campaign